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The AI Client Playbook

How freelancers, VAs, consultants and coaches get clients with AI

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Before you start

I spent more than 25 years building and running operations for coaching, consulting, SaaS and digital businesses. As COO of a business coaching company, I helped grow annual revenue from about \$5 million to \$16 million while keeping 35% net profit margins.

None of that growth came from luck or a viral post. It came from a pipeline: a steady, boring, repeatable process for finding the right people, starting conversations, following up, and turning conversations into clients.

Most independent professionals never get taught that process. They are great at the work, so they live on referrals. When referrals slow down, the calendar empties and panic sets in.

This playbook gives you the same pipeline discipline a sales team uses, sized for a business of one. AI does the heavy lifting: the research, the first drafts, the follow-up reminders. You do the part that only a human can do, which is to show up as yourself and build trust.

How to use this playbook

- **Read it once, start to finish.** It's short on purpose.
- **Do the "Your move" at the end of each chapter.** Each one takes 15 to 45 minutes.
- **Keep one AI assistant open** while you read. ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini or Copilot all work. Every prompt in this book is written to work in any of them.
- **Fill in every [bracket]** in a prompt before you send it. The more specific you are, the better the result.

The one rule

AI drafts. You decide. Never send anything AI wrote without reading it, cutting it, and making it sound like you. Prospects can smell a generic message from a mile away, and one lazy message costs you more than ten good ones earn.

Chapter 1: Pick a client worth chasing

The fastest way to get more clients is to get clear on fewer of them.

When you say "I help small businesses with marketing," nobody feels like you are talking to them. When you say "I help independent physical therapy clinics fill their schedules without paying for ads," the right clinic owner leans in.

Being specific feels risky. In practice it's the opposite. A clear target makes every other step in this playbook easier: finding prospects, writing messages, and closing.

Step 1: Look at your best past clients

Think about the 3 clients you most enjoyed working with, who paid on time, and who got great results. If you are just starting, think about the people you most *want* to work with and why.

Paste them into this prompt:

Prompt: Find your best-fit client

I'm a [your role] who helps [type of client] with [result]. My three favorite past clients were: [describe each in one line: what they do, size, what you did for them, why it went well].

Based on what they have in common, describe my ideal client in 5 bullet points: industry, size, role of the decision maker, the problem that makes them look for help, and where they spend time online. Then tell me which of these clients I should be cautious about targeting and why.

Step 2: Name the problem they'll pay to fix

People don't buy services. They buy a way out of a problem that's costing them money, time or sleep.

Prompt: Find the expensive problem

My ideal client is [paste the 5 bullets]. List the 7 most common problems they have that I could solve with [your service]. For each, tell me (1) what it costs them in money or time, (2) the words they'd use to describe it to a friend, and (3) how urgent it usually feels. Rank the list from most to least urgent.

Pick the one problem near the top that you are best at solving. That's the problem you lead with.

Step 3: Write your one sentence

You need a single sentence that tells a stranger, in five seconds, whether you are for them.

Prompt: Sharpen your offer

Here is how I describe what I do today: [paste]. My ideal client is [paste] and their most urgent problem is [paste]. Rewrite my description as one plain sentence using the format "I help [who] [get result] without [pain]." Give me 5 versions from most conservative to boldest. No jargon, no buzzwords.

Read the 5 versions out loud. Pick the one you would actually say at a dinner party. Tweak it until it sounds like you.

Step 4: Package an offer they can say yes to

A vague offer ("let's hop on a call and see how I can help") is hard to buy. A clear offer has a name, a result, a scope and a price.

Prompt: Package your offer

I help [your one sentence]. Suggest 3 ways to package this as a clear, fixed-scope offer: a small starter offer, a core offer, and a premium offer. For each give a name, what's included, how long it takes, the result the client gets, and a price range that is typical for [your market/country] for someone with [your experience level]. Keep each description under 60 words.

You don't need to sell all three right away. Most people start by selling the core offer and using the starter offer as an easy first yes.

Your move

Write these four things down where you can see them:

1. Your ideal client, in 5 bullets
2. The urgent problem you solve
3. Your one sentence
4. Your core offer and price

Everything in the rest of this playbook builds on them.

Chapter 2: Build a prospect list with AI

A pipeline starts with names. Not "people on LinkedIn," but a specific list of real people you could contact this week.

Your goal for this chapter: **a list of 50 real prospects**. It sounds like a lot. With AI helping, it's an afternoon.

Step 1: Find where your clients gather

Prompt: Find the watering holes

My ideal client is [paste your 5 bullets]. List 15 specific places they spend time online or in person where I could start real conversations: named LinkedIn groups, Facebook groups, Slack or Discord communities, subreddits, newsletters, podcasts, associations, conferences, local meetups and hashtags. For each, give one sentence on how to show up there in a helpful way without pitching.

AI can suggest communities that don't exist or no longer exist. Spend 10 minutes checking the list and keep the 5 most active real places.

Step 2: Use your warm network first

Your easiest clients are people who already know you. Most people skip this step because it feels awkward. Don't skip it.

Make a list of:

- Past clients
- Past coworkers and bosses
- People you've collaborated with
- Friends who run businesses or work in your target industry
- Other freelancers who serve the same clients but do something different (they're your best referral partners)

Aim for 20 names. You'll write to them in Chapter 3.

Step 3: Find new people who fit

Now add 30 people you don't know yet. Good places to look:

- **LinkedIn search** filtered by job title, industry and location

- **Members and commenters** in the communities from Step 1
- **Podcast guests and newsletter authors** in your niche
- **Directories** (industry associations, local business lists, "top 50" lists)
- **Companies that are hiring** for the work you do. A job post is a sign of a problem and a budget.

For each person, capture: name, role, company, where you found them, and one specific thing you noticed about them. That last column is what makes your outreach work.

Step 4: Let AI do the research

Once you have a name and a company, AI can turn a website or profile into talking points in seconds.

Prompt: Research a prospect

Here is a prospect's website "About" page and their latest LinkedIn post: [paste both]. I help [your one sentence]. Give me (1) a 2-sentence summary of their business, (2) 3 signs they might have [the problem you solve], (3) one specific, genuine detail I could mention in a first message, and (4) a 1-to-5 score for how good a fit they are, with a reason.

Only paste in information that's public. Never paste anyone's private data into an AI tool.

Step 5: Score and sort

You don't have time to write to everyone with the same care. Sort your list into:

- **A:** great fit, clear sign of the problem. Write a fully personal message.
- **B:** good fit, no clear sign yet. Write a lighter personal message.
- **C:** not sure. Follow them, engage with their posts, revisit in a month.

Your move

Build your first list of 50 names (20 warm, 30 new) in the pipeline tracker or any spreadsheet. Score each one A, B or C.

Chapter 3: Write outreach in your own voice

This is where most people either freeze ("I don't know what to say") or ask AI to "write a cold email" and send something that sounds like everyone else's.

You're going to do it differently. First you'll teach AI how you write. Then you'll use it to draft short, specific messages that you finish by hand.

Step 1: Teach AI your voice

Find 3 things you've written that sound like you: an email to a client, a LinkedIn post, a text to a colleague. Casual is fine. Real is the point.

Prompt: Teach AI your voice

Here are 3 messages I've written that sound like me: [paste]. Describe my writing style in 6 short rules covering tone, sentence length, words I use often, words I never use, how I open and how I close. Then rewrite this generic message in my style: "Hi, I hope this message finds you well. I wanted to reach out to see if you might be interested in my services."

Save the 6 rules. Paste them at the top of every outreach prompt from now on, or save them in your AI tool's custom instructions or project settings.

Step 2: Know what a good first message looks like

A good first message is:

- **Short.** Under 80 words. Three or four sentences.
- **About them.** It mentions one specific, true thing about them.
- **Connected.** It links that thing to a problem you solve.
- **Low pressure.** It ends with an easy question, not a demand for a call.

It is not a pitch, a résumé, or a list of your services.

A simple structure that works:

1. **Notice:** something specific about them
2. **Connect:** why it made you think of a common problem
3. **Credibility:** one line on what you do (optional)
4. **Ask:** a small, easy question

Step 3: Draft messages to new prospects

Prompt: Write a personal first message

My voice rules: [paste]. Here's what I know about the prospect: [paste research from Chapter 2]. I help [your one sentence]. Write a first message under 80 words that mentions one specific detail about them, connects it to [the problem], and ends with a low-pressure question. No flattery, no exclamation marks, no "I hope this finds you well." Give me 2 versions: one for LinkedIn and one for email with a subject line under 6 words.

Then edit. Cut any sentence you wouldn't say out loud. Check every fact.

Example (VA writing to a coach):

Hi Maya, I saw your team just launched the new group program. Congrats. When coaches scale a launch like that, the inbox and calendar usually break first. I help coaches hand that off in the first two weeks. Worth a quick chat to see if it fits?

Step 4: Write to your warm network

Warm messages are even simpler. You're not selling. You're letting people know what you do now and asking for a little help.

Prompt: Reconnect with a past contact

My voice rules: [paste]. Write a short, warm check-in message to [name], who I worked with on [project] about [time] ago. Mention something specific about our work together, share that I now help [your one sentence], and ask if they know anyone who might need that. Under 70 words. Don't ask them to hire me.

Many first clients come from these messages, either directly or through a referral.

Step 5: Choose your channels

Use the channel your clients actually answer:

- **LinkedIn:** best for B2B, consultants, and corporate clients
- **Email:** best when you can find a business address and have a clear reason to write
- **Community DMs:** only after you've been helpful in the community first
- **Instagram/Facebook DMs:** works well for coaches and creators, keep it extra casual

- **Referral partners:** a message to another freelancer can bring you a steady stream of clients

Pick one or two. Doing two channels well beats doing five badly.

A note on volume

You don't need to send 100 messages a day. For most solo businesses, **5 to 10 thoughtful new messages a day, a few days a week** is plenty to keep a pipeline full. Quality beats quantity every time.

Your move

Write your voice rules. Then send your first 10 messages: 5 to warm contacts and 5 to A-list prospects.

Chapter 4: Follow up without being pushy

Here's the truth that changes everything: **most people won't reply to your first message**. Not because they're not interested, but because they're busy. Your message landed during a meeting, got buried, and was forgotten.

Many sales happen after several touches. Most freelancers send one message, hear nothing, and quietly give up. If you simply follow up well, you'll be ahead of most of your competition.

The rule of value

Every follow-up should give something, not just ask. "Just bumping this to the top of your inbox" gives nothing. A useful tip, a relevant link, or a quick observation about their business gives them a reason to reply.

A simple 5-touch rhythm

Touch	When	What it does
1	Day 1	Your first message
2	Day 3 to 4	A short, friendly nudge with one useful idea
3	Day 8 to 10	Share a resource: a checklist, an article, a quick tip
4	Day 15 to 18	A different angle: a result you got for someone similar
5	Day 25 to 30	The polite close: "I'll stop here, door's open"

After touch 5, move them to a "check back in 90 days" list. Never argue, never guilt-trip, and stop immediately if someone asks you to.

Draft a full sequence in one go

Prompt: Write a follow-up sequence

My voice rules: [paste]. I sent this first message [paste] to [prospect description] [days] days ago and got no reply. Write 4 follow-ups to send over the next 4 weeks. Touch 2: short nudge with one useful idea. Touch 3: share a helpful resource about [topic]. Touch 4: a short story about a result for a similar client (use a placeholder I can fill in with a real example). Touch 5: a polite close that leaves the door open. Each under 60 words. No guilt, no pressure.

Use a real result in Touch 4. If you don't have one yet, use what you've learned ("The fastest fix I've seen for this is...").

The polite close

The last message often gets the most replies, because it removes all pressure:

Hi [Name], I haven't heard back, so I'll assume the timing isn't right and stop filling your inbox. If [problem] ever moves up the list, I'm easy to find. Wishing you a great quarter.

When they reply "not right now"

"Not right now" is not "no." Ask one question, then set a reminder.

Totally understand. Out of curiosity, when do you usually plan for this kind of thing? I'll make a note to check in then.

Then actually check in then. Most people won't, and that's why you'll win.

Your move

Write a 5-touch sequence for your A-list. Put the follow-up dates in your tracker or calendar.

Chapter 5: Turn conversations into calls

Replies are great. Calls are where clients happen. This chapter covers how to move a conversation to a call and how to run that call so it ends with a next step.

Moving to a call

When someone replies with interest, don't send a wall of text about your services. Make it easy to talk.

Glad that was useful. It's easier to give you a real answer on a quick call. Want to grab 20 minutes this week? Here's my calendar: [booking link]

A booking link removes the back-and-forth. Calendly, Cal.com and TidyCal all have free plans.

Prep in 5 minutes with AI

Never walk into a call cold. Five minutes of prep makes you sound like you've been studying their business for a week.

Prompt: Prep for a discovery call

I have a discovery call with [name], [role] at [company]. Here is their website/LinkedIn summary and our message thread: [paste]. I help [your one sentence]. Give me: (1) 3 problems they're most likely facing, (2) 6 open-ended questions to ask, in a natural order, (3) 2 objections they might raise and a calm, honest response to each, and (4) one question that will help me understand their budget and timeline.

Run the call: a simple structure

A good discovery call is mostly listening. Aim to talk less than a third of the time.

1. **Set the agenda (1 min).** "I'd love to hear about what's going on, share how I usually help, and if it seems like a fit we can talk about next steps. Sound good?"
2. **Their situation (5 to 10 min).** What's happening now? What have they tried?
3. **The problem and its cost (5 min).** What happens if nothing changes? What's it costing them?
4. **The result they want (3 min).** If this went perfectly, what would be different in 90 days?
5. **Your approach (3 to 5 min).** Briefly, how you'd help. Tie it to their words.
6. **Next step (2 min).** Never end without one.

The questions that matter most

- "What made you reply to my message now?"
- "What have you already tried?"
- "What happens if this doesn't get fixed this quarter?"
- "Who else is involved in a decision like this?"
- "Is there a budget you had in mind, or should I give you a few options?"

Always end with a next step

Before you hang up, agree on what happens next and when.

"Based on what you've shared, I think [core offer] would fit. I'll send a one-page proposal by Thursday. Can we put 15 minutes on the calendar Friday to go through it?"

After the call

Prompt: Summarize a discovery call

Here are my rough notes from a discovery call: [paste]. Summarize: their situation in their own words, the problem and what it costs them, the result they want, budget and timeline signals, decision makers, and any concerns. Then draft a short thank-you email that recaps the 3 most important points and confirms the next step.

Your move

Set up a free booking link. Write your call agenda on a sticky note. Book your first call.

Chapter 6: Proposals and pricing that close

A proposal isn't a contract or a brochure. It's a one-page summary of the conversation you already had, with a clear price and a clear next step.

The one-page proposal

1. **Their situation**, in their words
2. **The result they want**
3. **Your recommended approach** in 3 steps
4. **Timeline**
5. **Investment** (one recommended option, or three tiers)
6. **Next step** and how to say yes

Prompt: Draft a proposal

My voice rules: [paste]. Here is my call summary: [paste]. Write a one-page proposal using these sections: their situation in their own words, the result they want, my recommended approach in 3 steps, timeline, investment of [price], and next step. Plain language, no jargon, under 400 words. Make it about them, not me.

Then edit. Check that every promise in the proposal is something you can actually deliver.

Pricing with confidence

- **Price the result, not your hours.** "Fill your calendar with 10 discovery calls a month" is worth more than "10 hours of VA support."
- **Offer three options when it makes sense.** A starter, a core and a premium option let people choose how to work with you instead of whether to.
- **Say your price out loud, then stop talking.** Silence is fine.
- **Don't discount on the spot.** If budget is a real issue, reduce the scope instead of the price.

Handling the common objections

Objections are usually questions in disguise. Answer them honestly.

"It's more than I expected."

"That's fair. Can I ask what you were comparing it to? If budget's the main concern, I could [smaller scope option] and we can add the rest later."

"I need to think about it."

"Of course. Usually when people say that, there's one part they're not sure about. Is it the price, the timing, or whether this will work for you?"

"I need to talk to my partner/team."

"Makes sense. What questions do you think they'll ask? I can put the answers in a short email you can forward."

"Can you send more information?"

"Happy to. What specifically would be most helpful to see?"

Prompt: Prepare for objections

I'm sending a proposal for [offer] at [price] to [client description]. List the 5 objections they're most likely to raise and write an honest, calm, two-sentence response to each in my voice: [paste voice rules].

Follow up on proposals

Proposals go quiet too. Use a short version of the Chapter 4 rhythm:

- **Day 2:** "Did you have a chance to look? Any questions I can answer?"
- **Day 5:** Share one helpful thing related to their goal.
- **Day 10:** "Should I keep this open, or has the timing changed?"

Your move

Write a proposal template for your core offer. Practice saying your price out loud until it sounds normal to you.

Chapter 7: Your 30-minute weekly pipeline routine

Everything in this playbook works only if you keep doing it. The good news is that it doesn't take long. The secret is consistency, not intensity.

Here's the routine I recommend. Put it on your calendar as a recurring appointment with yourself.

The weekly routine

Monday (30 minutes): Plan and build - Review your tracker. Who needs a follow-up this week?
- Add 10 new prospects to your list (Chapter 2) - Research your top 5 with AI

Tuesday and Thursday (20 minutes each): Reach out - Send 5 new personal messages (Chapter 3) - Send all follow-ups that are due (Chapter 4)

Wednesday (15 minutes): Be visible - Post one helpful thing where your clients gather, or comment thoughtfully on 5 posts - Reply to every comment and message

Friday (15 minutes): Review - Update your tracker - Check your numbers (below) - Write down one thing to improve next week

That's under two hours a week. For most solo businesses, it's enough to stop the feast-and-famine cycle for good.

The four numbers to watch

You don't need a complicated dashboard. Track these four numbers every week:

1. **Messages sent** (new + follow-ups)
2. **Replies**
3. **Calls booked**
4. **Clients signed**

Over time you'll learn your own conversion rates. For example: if 50 messages lead to 10 replies, 3 calls and 1 client, you know that one new client takes about 50 messages. Need two more clients next month? Send 100 messages. That is how you take control of your income.

What to fix when the numbers are low

- **Few replies?** Your messages are too long, too generic or going to the wrong people. Revisit Chapters 1 and 3.
- **Replies but no calls?** You're not making it easy to book. Add a link and a clear invitation.
- **Calls but no clients?** Your offer isn't clear or the price isn't tied to a result. Revisit Chapters 1 and 6.

Let AI be your sales assistant

Prompt: Weekly pipeline review

Here's my pipeline this week: [paste your tracker rows or numbers]. My goal is [number] new clients this month. Tell me (1) who I should follow up with first and why, (2) whether my numbers suggest a problem with my messages, my calls or my offer, and (3) the 3 most important actions for next week.

Your move

Put the routine on your calendar right now as recurring blocks. Then do it for 4 weeks before judging the results.

Your 30-day action plan

Week 1: Foundation - Chapter 1: ideal client, problem, one sentence, offer - Chapter 3: write your voice rules - Set up your tracker and booking link

Week 2: Warm start - Message 20 warm contacts - Build your list of 30 new prospects - Send your first 10 new-prospect messages

Week 3: Rhythm - Run the weekly routine - Send follow-ups on schedule - Book and prep your first calls

Week 4: Close and review - Send proposals within 2 days of each call - Follow up on every proposal - Review your four numbers and adjust

Where to go from here

Want every prompt, script and sequence done for you? The AI Client Kit includes 100+ ready-to-use prompts, outreach scripts for every channel, ready-made follow-up sequences, and the pipeline tracker spreadsheet. Find it at virtualexpert.net/templates.

Want personal help? In a Client Pipeline Audit, I review your offer, outreach and follow-up and give you a prioritized plan built for your business. Book a discovery call at virtualexpert.net/consulting.

Now close this book and send your first message.

Denise

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